

But can you live without the job itself? Without a secretary to do your bidding? Without the challenge of making a buck in a market that's turned against you? Without the power, responsibility, and sense of getting something done? Without going to the office every day? Without two-hour meetings, career counseling, and that first cup of coffee at your desk each morning?

Before retiring I had lunch with a 50-year-old friend who had been eased out of the law firm he had founded. He felt disoriented and frustrated. Money was no problem—he had inherited quite a stash—but the office had been his life. A few years before, he had told me that stress on the job had ruined his marriage and caused a mild heart attack. He had willingly paid the price—until now. Now he was so frightened of the future that he had trouble choosing from the menu, not to mention putting together a new life for himself.

He panicked when I told him I was going to retire at age 35.

“Don’t do it,” he told me. “You’ll be cut off. No one will call. No one will ask your advice. Hell, you won’t even get any *mail*. You laugh, but I know what I’m talking about. It’s a problem.”

Just before making the final decision to retire, I went to New York on business. After a day at the Peat Marwick office on Park Avenue, I ran into a young acquaintance. He had designed dresses for years, bouncing from one job to another in New York’s Seventh Avenue garment district. When his dresses didn’t sell, he was out the door faster than a Federal Express package. The jobs paid well when he had them, but he needed every dime to keep up with high New York prices. He lived in a fifth-floor walkup that the landlord figured was worth about the same as the King Ranch in Texas. A drink in the bar around the corner cost the same as a day’s pay in most countries in the world. (In chapter 5 I review living costs in the United States and around the world. I give you a list of U.S. cities where you can live well on \$50 a day. New York is not one of them.)